

OpenPrivateer Player Manual

Public Alpha

OpenPrivateer is a modern reimplementation of *Wing Commander: Privateer*. It runs the game natively on modern systems while using the original game data.

OpenPrivateer does not include the original Origin/EA game assets. You need your own copy of *Privateer* and, if you want to play it, *Righteous Fire*.

This is a player manual. The reverse-engineering notes and file-format documentation in the source tree go much deeper.

1. Quick Start

1. Download and extract OpenPrivateer.
2. Start `openprivateer.exe` on Windows, or the corresponding executable on Linux or macOS.
3. The launcher opens. Select **Privateer** or **Righteous Fire** at the top.
4. Open **Game Data** and provide the original game files:
 - Privateer: `PRIV.TRE` and `INITCFG.PAK`
 - Righteous Fire: `RF.TRE` and `INITRF.PAK`
5. Use **Import to Data Folder...** to copy files from another folder, or **Add Folder...** to use files where they already are.
6. Click **PLAY**, then **NEW**.

The launcher shows the exact files it found and the folder each one comes from. You can also put the files next to the OpenPrivateer program; the launcher searches the Program Folder automatically.

The INIT files contain the original new-pilot starting state. If the matching INIT file is missing, **NEW** is disabled.

You do not need *Righteous Fire* to play the original campaign.

GOG installation

With the GOG release, `INITCFG.PAK` and `INITRF.PAK` are in the game installation folder. `PRIV.TRE` and `RF.TRE` are inside the `GAME.GOG` disc image and can be extracted with 7-Zip.

After extracting the TRE files, either collect the required files in one folder and import that folder, or add the folders containing them to the Game Data search path.

2. First Start and the Launcher

The launcher is OpenPrivateer's startup screen. It selects the game, locates the original game data and provides the main startup settings before the engine loads the game.

At the top, click the **Privateer** or **Righteous Fire** picture to choose the game. Your own `wallpaper/` artwork is used when present (section 19). On the left, the launcher shows the selected game's TRE and INIT file, their status and the exact path being used. **PLAY** stays disabled until the selected game's TRE file is found.

The launcher sections are:

- **Experience:** choose Classic, Enhanced or Modern (section 4).
- **Game Data:** manage where OpenPrivateer finds the four original game files.
- **Music:** choose the music backend and an optional SoundFont (section 17).
- **Original Developer Switches:** set the original `-K`, `-B` and `-D` startup switches (section 24).
- **Files and Diagnostics:** open user-data folders, move the user-data location, reset settings, copy diagnostics and control update checks.

Untick **Show this screen at startup** to go straight to the game next time. Hold **Shift** while starting OpenPrivateer to bring the launcher back. The launcher is always shown when required game data is missing.

Game Data

OpenPrivateer searches the Game Data rows from top to bottom and uses the first copy of each required file it finds. The table shows all four files and marks the copy currently selected as **Used**.

The **Type** column describes each search location:

- **Custom:** a folder added by the player. Its files are used in place.
- **Data Folder:** the `data/` folder where the launcher stores imported or copied game files.
- **User Home:** the current user-data folder.
- **Program Folder:** the folder containing the OpenPrivateer program. In portable mode this is also the user-data folder.

Command-line and environment search locations are identified by their corresponding source instead.

Other table states help explain duplicate files. **differs** means a different copy exists further down the search path but is not used. **same** means the later copy is identical. **case!** reports a filename with the wrong letter case on systems where that matters.

Folders added as **Custom** can be moved up or down or removed. A path can also be entered directly and added with **Add**. **Rescan** checks the search locations again.

The three main file actions are different:

- **Add Folder...** adds a folder to the search path and leaves its files where they are.
- **Import to Data Folder...** selects a folder and copies recognized game files from it into the Data Folder.
- **Copy Found Files to Data Folder** copies the game files currently being used into the Data Folder.

When OpenPrivateer recognizes a likely existing installation, the launcher can also offer to use its files in place or copy the files it finds.

Where your files live

Settings (`openprivateer.ini`), savegames, logs and optional folders live together in OpenPrivateer's user-data folder.

By default this is:

System	Folder
Windows	<code>%APPDATA%\OpenPrivateer</code>
Linux	<code>~/.local/share/OpenPrivateer</code>
macOS	<code>~/Library/Application Support/OpenPrivateer</code>

A portable installation instead keeps user data in the Program Folder. An existing `openprivateer.ini` next to the program keeps older portable installations working. An empty `portable.txt` can also be placed there to request portable mode.

Open **Files and Diagnostics** to see the folder currently in use. The section has direct buttons for the user-data folder, savegames, logs, music, wallpaper and content.

Change Data Folder... selects another location for user data. When switching folders, OpenPrivateer can either use the destination as it is or copy the current settings, saves, content, music, wallpaper and copied game files there before switching. Nothing is deleted from the old location. Depending on the current mode, the launcher also offers **Move to User Folder...** or **Use User Folder...**

If the location was fixed with `--home` or `OPENPRIV_HOME` , it cannot be changed from the launcher for that run.

Reset Settings... renames `openprivateer.ini` to `openprivateer.ini.bak` and restarts OpenPrivateer. Savegames are not touched.

OpenPrivateer creates its optional folders and README files in the user-data folder automatically. The README files are rewritten on startup so their instructions stay in sync with the installed engine.

Folder	Purpose
<code>savegame/</code>	Original and OpenPrivateer savegames
<code>music/</code>	Optional replacement music
<code>wallpaper/</code>	Optional game-selection artwork
<code>content/</code>	Content overrides and translations
<code>alpha/</code>	Optional material from the August 1993 Privateer alpha
<code>data/</code>	Game files imported or copied by the launcher
<code>logs/</code>	Session logs

You can ignore all of these folders when starting out.

3. Privateer and Righteous Fire

OpenPrivateer supports both the original *Privateer* campaign and *Righteous Fire*.

Choose the game by clicking its picture at the top of the launcher. With the launcher turned off and both `PRIV.TRE` and `RF.TRE` found, a startup selector lets you choose instead. The selection is remembered. You can also change the game later from the settings/debug overlay. Changing games while playing relaunches OpenPrivateer because the two modes use different data archives.

Importing a Privateer pilot into Righteous Fire

The original Righteous Fire import flow is supported.

If Righteous Fire is selected and the `savegame/` folder contains Privateer `.SAV` files, starting **NEW** can ask whether you want to load an old Privateer ship.

The import carries over the pilot, ship, credits, reputation, kills, guild memberships and missions-to-date state according to the original import behavior. Privateer cargo, side missions and plot progress do not become Righteous Fire campaign state.

4. Experience Modes

OpenPrivateer has three experience settings:

- **Classic**
- **Enhanced**
- **Modern**

Enhanced and Modern currently use the same gameplay behavior. The separate Modern setting exists for future changes.

Classic

Classic aims to reproduce the original gameplay, mechanics and feel. It is not a DOS emulator, and it does not deliberately reproduce every hardware limitation or arithmetic accident of the old engine.

Confirmed original behavior is kept where it was part of normal play, including many UI rules, equipment rules, cutscene rules and gameplay quirks.

OpenPrivateer additions such as multiple-ship ownership are not active in Classic.

Enhanced and Modern

Enhanced and Modern keep the original game underneath but allow OpenPrivateer conveniences and additions, including optional multiple ships and hired wingmen.

They also contain some deliberate quality-of-life changes, such as corrected sprite aspect while rolling and extra convenience controls.

If you want to compare OpenPrivateer directly with DOS Privateer, use **Classic**.

If you want OpenPrivateer's extra features, use **Enhanced** or **Modern**.

The Experience setting can be changed while playing. A connected multiplayer session is different: its Experience mode is fixed by the server.

5. Settings and Debug Overlay

During the Alpha, some settings still live in the debug/settings overlay rather than a finished front end.

Press:

~

This is normally the key to the left of **1** on an English keyboard. Its label depends on your keyboard layout.

The overlay contains settings for areas such as Experience mode, Privateer / Righteous Fire mode, audio, SoundFont, rendering, subtitles, Mission Computer style, controllers, multiple ships, hired wingmen and update checking.

Some settings are disabled in Classic because they would change original gameplay.

6. Controls

OpenPrivateer supports keyboard, mouse, gamepads, joysticks and HOTAS-style controllers.

Open **Controls...** from the settings interface to inspect or remap controls. Controller bindings are stored per device.

The same Controls screen can also be reached by pressing **K** on the Options screen, opened in flight or on a base with **Alt+O**.

OpenPrivateer can bind controller buttons, hats, axis directions and full analog axes.

Calibration

OpenPrivateer supports joystick calibration. A raw joystick needs at least two axes and one button to qualify as a flight controller. SDL-recognized gamepads are accepted directly.

If several devices are attached, devices that cannot actually fly the ship are skipped.

Default gamepad layout

Input	Default action
Left stick Y	Pitch
Left stick X	Yaw
Right stick X	Roll

Input	Default action
Right stick Y	Throttle
Right trigger	Fire guns
Right shoulder	Fire ordnance
Left trigger	Afterburner
Left shoulder	Cycle target
South button	Target lock
East button	Cycle ordnance
West button	Cycle guns
North button	Toggle ITTS
Start	Pause
Back	Navigation Map

These are normal remappable bindings.

Joystick pointer

A calibrated joystick can move the pointer on base and menu screens, matching a feature of the original game. The joystick trigger acts as the click. SDL gamepads use the A/South button.

7. New Game, Load and Save

The title screen has **NEW**, **LOAD**, **OPTIONS** and **QUIT**.

NEW

NEW starts from the original data in `INITCFG.PAK` or `INITRF.PAK`. If the matching file is missing, NEW is greyed out.

LOAD

Privateer saves use `.SAV`. Righteous Fire saves use `.PRS`.

Put existing DOS saves in the `savegame/` folder of the user-data folder (the launcher's **Savegames** button opens it):

```
savegame/
```

OpenPrivateer reads the original save format.

SAVE

Use the Mission Computer and choose **SAVE**.

Saving under a typed name never overwrites a file. Matching the original game, the name always gets `_NEW` appended (then `_NEW2`, `_NEW3`, ...) rather than reusing the plain name. Typing `PILOT` creates `PILOT_NEW.SAV`, not `PILOT.SAV`; saving under that same name again creates `PILOT_NEW2.SAV`, and so on.

Some OpenPrivateer-only state cannot fit inside the original DOS save format. That state is stored in a matching `.openpriv.json` sidecar while the `.SAV` or `.PRS` remains in the original format.

If you use parked ships or other OpenPrivateer-only persistent features, keep the sidecar together with its save.

8. Mission Computer

The Quine 4000 handles saves and pilot information.

Its important pages are:

- **MISSIONS**: active plot mission and accepted side missions
- **FIN**: cash, kills and faction standing
- **MAN**: cargo manifest
- **SAVE / LOAD**: save browser

A pilot can carry up to three side missions. The active plot mission is separate and does not consume one of those slots.

Classic uses the original Mission Computer presentation. Enhanced and Modern can use the alternate OpenPrivateer presentation through the **Quine Model** setting.

9. Bases

Base navigation is driven by the original `OPTIONS` and `GAMEFLOW` data.

Move the pointer over doors, people and terminals to see available actions, then click normally.

Depending on the base you may find the Launch Pad, Main Concourse, Bar, Commodity Exchange, Ship Dealer, Repair & Upgrade, Mission Computer, Merchants' Guild or Mercenaries' Guild.

Not every base contains every service.

10. Commodity Exchange

The Commodity Exchange buys and sells cargo. Left-click "Select Items" to buy or sell one unit. Right-click it to buy as many as you can afford and carry, or to sell everything you hold of that commodity, in every experience mode.

Prices and availability depend on the base economy. Cargo consumes hold space. Mission cargo follows the game's normal cargo rules.

The secret compartment, once obtained through the story, has separate hidden capacity.

11. Ship Dealer and Repair & Upgrade

With normal single-ship play, buying another hull follows the original trade-in model. The current hull and sellable equipment contribute to the trade-in value.

Repair & Upgrade handles ship equipment.

In Classic, entering Repair & Upgrade always starts in **Buy** mode on the first item, matching the original. Enhanced and Modern remember the previous mode and item where possible.

A damaged scanner can be repaired in the Software Booth's Repair Mode. Repair cost is based on the damaged scanner entry and damage percentage, matching the original game.

12. Multiple Ships and Fleet Selector

Multiple ships are an OpenPrivateer feature.

To use them:

1. Switch to Enhanced or Modern.
2. Enable **Allow Multiple Ships**.
3. Buy another hull.

Instead of trading in the old ship, OpenPrivateer parks it at the current base and makes the new hull active.

On a Launch Pad press:

S

to open the Fleet Selector.

The active ship is marked as current. Parked ships can be selected or sold. Remote selection of a ship parked at another base is supported.

Multiple ships are not active in Classic.

13. Hired Wingmen

Hired wingmen are an OpenPrivateer feature built on top of multiple-ship ownership.

Enable **Allow Multiple Ships** and **Allow Hired Wingmen** in Enhanced or Modern mode.

A hired pilot flies one of your actual owned parked ships. If the wingman survives, the ship returns with its live equipment state. If it is destroyed, the ship is lost.

Pilots have persistent callsigns and skill. Confirmed kills can improve their skill. Launching with a wingman costs a sortie fee.

A ship assigned to a hired pilot cannot simply be selected or sold as an ordinary parked ship.

Custom callsigns

The callsign pool is stored in:

```
content/wingmen/callsigns.json
```

OpenPrivateer creates the default file if it is missing and does not overwrite an edited version.

The file is a JSON array of non-empty strings. Existing pilots keep their callsigns. Changes affect later hires.

Plain ASCII names are safest with the original game fonts.

14. Flight

The flight model is reconstructed from the original game rather than replaced with a new one.

Implemented systems include flight control, throttle, afterburner, guns, ordnance, targeting, ITTS, radar, scanners, navigation, autopilot, jumps, docking, tractor beam, turrets, equipment damage and Repair Droid behavior.

Scanner

Targeting requires a working scanner.

With no scanner fitted, the radar is absent and scanner-dependent targeting functions are unavailable. There is no hidden free scanner.

Autopilot

Autopilot follows the original instant-travel behavior. It can drop out early when the route enters another encounter zone, including asteroid or navigation encounter areas.

Pause

Press **P** in flight.

15. Navigation Map

The Navigation Map uses the original sector and quadrant data.

It shows systems, nav points, bases, jump points and mission objectives. Story-locked systems and routes remain hidden until the game makes them available.

Active mission targets are highlighted.

The optional **Open Universe** setting exposes additional universe content and is not part of Classic behavior.

16. Guilds and Random Missions

The Merchants' Guild, Mercenaries' Guild and Mission Computer provide the original non-plot mission types:

- Cargo
- Patrol
- Scout
- Defend
- Attack
- Bounty

Guild fees are:

Guild	Fee
Merchants' Guild	1,000 credits
Mercenaries' Guild	5,000 credits

Both guild computers show the original **Scanning ... records ... Please stand by...** stage while generating a fresh batch of offers.

17. Music and Sound

OpenPrivateer supports several music backends, including OPL2, MIDI with an external SoundFont, OS MIDI and CD-style replacement music. Availability depends on the platform.

SoundFont

Select a `.sf2` file in the launcher's **Music** section or from the SoundFont setting when using the corresponding MIDI backend. The path is stored in `openprivateer.ini`. Without one, OpenPrivateer looks for `openprivateer.sf2` in the user-data folder, then next to the program.

Replacement music

The `music/` folder accepts optional replacement music. WAV, MP3 and FLAC are supported.

Use the generated `music/README.txt` for the current slot and filename rules. That README is kept in sync with the installed build.

18. Graphics

OpenPrivateer renders the original game at its native logical resolution and scales it for modern displays.

Available settings include CRT filtering, image adjustments, scaling, texture filtering, pixel scaling and splash font selection.

Classic deliberately keeps some confirmed original rendering behavior. Enhanced and Modern apply some presentation improvements, such as keeping round sprites round while the ship rolls.

19. Wallpaper

The `wallpaper/` folder accepts custom artwork for the Privateer / Righteous Fire selector.

Use filenames beginning with:

```
01_
```

for Privateer and:

```
02_
```

for Righteous Fire.

PNG, JPG and BMP are supported. See `wallpaper/README.txt` for the current details.

20. Content Overrides and Translations

OpenPrivateer can load replacement files from the filesystem without changing the original TRE archives.

The basic layout is:

```
content/  
  priv/  
  rf/  
  i18n/
```

`content/priv/` and `content/rf/` mirror paths inside the corresponding original archive.

Translations live under `content/i18n/` with names such as:

```
openprivateer_de.i18n
```

The translation format uses `key=value`, `#` comments and `\n` for embedded line breaks.

The original fonts have limited character coverage. Plain ASCII or transliteration is safest unless a suitable custom font is used.

21. Optional 1993 Alpha Content

The `alpha/` folder is for optional material from the August 1993 Privateer alpha.

It is not distributed with OpenPrivateer and is not required to play.

See `alpha/README.txt` for the exact files expected by your build.

22. Multiplayer

OpenPrivateer includes dedicated client/server multiplayer. It is still an Alpha feature.

Server

Basic example:

```
openprivateer_server --tre /path/to/PRIV.TRE
```

The default UDP port is `24601`.

Useful server options include `--port`, `--max-players`, `--verbose` and `--experience-mode`.

Client

Basic example:

```
openprivateer --connect HOST:24601 /path/to/PRIV.TRE
```

The server can reject clients when important session properties differ, including build, Privateer vs. Righteous Fire data or Experience mode.

Multiplayer covers the shared flight/combat environment. The normal single-player campaign progression is not the multiplayer campaign model.

23. Update Check

Release builds can check for a newer OpenPrivateer build at most once every 24 hours.

Nothing is downloaded or installed automatically.

When a newer build exists, the title screen shows:

```
New build available
```

```
Click to download
```

Left-click opens the download page. Right-click dismisses that particular build notice.

The check can be disabled in settings or for one launch with:

```
--no-update-check
```

24. Original Developer Switches

OpenPrivateer supports several switches from the original game:

```
-K
```

Skip the intro.

```
-B<n>
```

Start at original base ID `n`.

```
-D<n>
```

Set starting credits to `n`.

Example:

```
openprivateer.exe -K -B39 -D100000
```

These are mainly useful for testing and development.

The launcher's **Original Developer Switches** section sets the same three as checkboxes that are remembered and apply on every start. Switches given on the command line win.

Other command-line options

```
openprivateer --help
```

lists every option. The ones for files and the launcher:

Option	Effect
<code>--home DIR</code>	Use <code>DIR</code> as the user-data folder for this run
<code>--portable</code>	Use the program's folder as the user-data folder
<code>--data DIR</code>	Look for the game files in <code>DIR</code> first
<code>--launcher</code>	Show the launcher

Option	Effect
<code>--no-launcher</code>	Never show it; exit with an error if files are missing

`OPENPRIV_HOME` and `OPENPRIV_DATA` (a list separated like `PATH`) are the environment-variable versions of `--home` and `--data`.

25. Debug Tools

The Alpha contains debugging tools used during reconstruction and testing.

Open the settings/debug overlay with:

```
~
```

Toggle the base click-region overlay with:

```
R
```

The region overlay draws clickable areas in green and is useful for screenshots when reporting a base UI problem.

26. Troubleshooting

NEW is greyed out

The matching seed file is missing. Privateer needs `INITCFG.PAK`; Righteous Fire needs `INITRF.PAK`. Copy it in with the launcher (hold Shift while starting if it is turned off), or put it next to its `.TRE` file.

The game data cannot be found

The launcher lists every folder it searched and which files it found. Use **Import to Data Folder...** to copy files in, or **Add Folder...** to use them where they are. On Linux, a file named `priv.tre` is reported as “wrong letter case”: rename it to `PRIV.TRE`.

With the GOG release, `PRIV.TRE` and `RF.TRE` are inside `GAME.GOG` and can be extracted with 7-Zip. The two INIT PAK files are in the game installation folder.

Where are my settings and saves?

Open the launcher’s **Files and Diagnostics** section. It shows the user-data folder currently in use and provides buttons for the folder, savegames, logs, music, wallpaper and content.

An old save does not appear

Privateer saves must be `.SAV`, Righteous Fire saves `.PRS`. Put them in the `savegame/` folder of the user-data folder.

The controller is detected but does not fly the ship

Open **Controls...**, check the device and calibration, then verify the axis bindings. A raw joystick needs at least two axes and one button.

MIDI is silent

Check the selected music backend. If using SoundFont MIDI, make sure a valid `.sf2` file is selected.

Something behaves differently from DOS Privateer

Check the Experience mode first. Use **Classic** for direct comparisons with the original.

If the difference remains in Classic, report it.

Windows Defender reports the executable

New unsigned software can occasionally trigger heuristic antivirus detections. Do not blindly whitelist a file.

Make sure the binary came from the official OpenPrivateer release, then update Windows Security's security intelligence and scan it again. During Alpha testing, an unchanged OpenPrivateer release binary stopped being detected after a Defender signature update.

If a current official build is still detected, report the build ID and exact detection name.

27. Reporting Bugs

A useful Alpha bug report includes:

- OpenPrivateer build ID
- Privateer or Righteous Fire
- Classic, Enhanced or Modern
- what you expected
- what happened
- exact reproduction steps
- whether it happens every time
- the savegame when relevant
- a screenshot or video for visual problems
- for startup or file problems, the text from the launcher's **Copy Diagnostics** button

Print the build ID with:

```
openprivateer --version
```

For base-screen problems, a screenshot with the `R` region overlay can help.

You do not need to decide whether something is an OpenPrivateer bug or an original Privateer quirk before reporting it. Describe what happened and it can be checked against the original.

28. What Alpha Means

OpenPrivateer is playable, but it is still an Alpha.

The normal single-player Privateer path is implemented, and Righteous Fire support is under active reconstruction and testing. Obscure cases are still being found as more people play the game.

Expect bugs, unfinished polish and occasional behavior changes as the original game becomes better understood.

Save before doing anything adventurous.

29. Help and Downloads

Project website:

<https://openprivateer.org/>

Downloads:

<https://openprivateer.org/#downloads>

Discord:

<https://discord.gg/5H3vW2STqW>

When asking for help, include the build ID and whether you are playing Privateer or Righteous Fire.

30. Legal Note

OpenPrivateer is a reimplementation of the game engine.

It does not ship the copyrighted game data from *Wing Commander: Privateer* or *Righteous Fire*. You must provide the original game files yourself.

Wing Commander, *Privateer*, *Righteous Fire* and related names and assets belong to their respective rights holders.

31. One-Minute Checklist

For Privateer:

- ☐ Extract OpenPrivateer
- ☐ Start OpenPrivateer
- ☐ Launcher: copy in PRIV.TRE and INITCFG.PAK
- ☐ Leave Experience on Classic for original behavior
- ☐ Click PLAY, then NEW

For Righteous Fire:

- ☐ Launcher: copy in RF.TRE and INITRF.PAK
- ☐ Select Righteous Fire

For an old pilot:

- ☐ Launcher: Files and Diagnostics, Savegames
- ☐ Copy .SAV or .PRS there
- ☐ Click LOAD

For OpenPrivateer's extra features:

- ☐ Switch to Enhanced or Modern
- ☐ Open the settings overlay with ~
- ☐ Enable the features you want

Have fun.